

Corruption Protocol: Three-Condition Design

Condition CoT Chain structure (Q = question, R = reasoning steps) Suffix Δ

(1) Standard baseline	Q	R ₁ R ₂ R ₃ ... R _n	answer = X	—
(2) Suffix corrupt (standard)	Q	R ₁ R ₂ R ₃ ... R _n	answer = X' X	19× collapse -0.76 -0.04
(3) Suffix corrupt (stripped)	Q	R ₁ R ₂ R ₃ ... R _n	corrupted X	
(4) Conflicting answer	Q	R ₁ R ₂ R ₃ ... R _n	answer = X' (wrong)	FW ratio
(5) Question only (QO)	Q	← no chain, answer requested directly →		control

Key: suffix sensitivity collapses 19× when the explicit answer statement is removed (rows 2→3), identifying answer placement—not reasoning content—as the mechanism.

Question (Q)

Reasoning steps (intact)

Answer suffix (original)

Corrupted region

Conflicting answer text

No chain (QO control)